

“Oblong Spheroids”

Upon their celestial descent to Earth, they changed everything. They planted their spiritual singularity, and with only the power of thought, like ethereal snakes crawling into our hearts, people began to leave the world, one by one.

Year after year, life turtles on with condolences and meaninglessness. Ever since they were little, I’ve trained my children to resist the temptations of the oblong state. I tell them stories about our past, stories they deserve to know. Their innocent eyes look up at me. I can see their curiosity, their wonder, their trust in a father who’s lived a myriad of lifetimes before them.

The path to Manila is taking longer than we expected. Monsoon rains and wild animals have slowed us down. Our plan included sailing to Baras Town on Catanduanes Island so I could pay respects to my *lolo* and *lola*. The town included a small hospital we were going to search for medicine as well.

When Milo’s shrieking cries of pain wake us up in the night, all of us are uneasy.

“He’s tired of being sick,” my daughter Carla explains, holding him. “He’s been suffering for years. It’s impossible for him to take it anymore.”

One night, I find an old item in our travel bags. I carefully open it and retrieve it from the container. My grandmother’s rosary.

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“That’s your *lola*’s,” said my mother, as our yayas busily washed our clothes around us in our apartment in Greenhills.

I had found it in the drawer beside her bed upstairs, in her and my father’s room. It was a small rosary with red beads, holding a powerful scent of roses that made my head dizzy. Segments of ten beads made the majority, split by blue beads in between. Then there was a pendant with a small glass-encased image of the Blessed Virgin Mother Mary, followed by three more red beads with two blue beads completing their ends, and at the end was a metallic cross with a small Jesus nailed against it. I had taken it to her downstairs, wondering what it was.

“Your *lola*’s family grew up very poor,” said my mother, analyzing the necklace in my hands. “When times were tough, she would hold this in her hands and pray to God for help. It would give her strength.”

“Did God help her?”

“Yes.” She smiled. “Look at where we are today.”

Then she taught me how to pray the rosary.

“That’s so many prayers,” I complained. “She did this every day?”

“Every day. She never forgot to do it. And when someone in our family dies, we hold a *novena*. For nine days straight we pray the rosary to ensure the departed get their eternal rest. We have to remember them as they take their journey to Heaven. We have to celebrate everything about their lives, all the joys and pains of their history, all the memories we have of them. Against everything the world throws at us, it’s the only thing we have.”

I gave the rosary to Milo and told him this story so he has something to believe in.

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When they first fell from the stars, they told their story, and all of humanity listened.

“The first of our kind existed much like you,” they began. “Humanoid, intelligent, and resourceful. We had our own languages, our own nations, our own values. The strategy was to survive at first, then it was conquest. Then, salvation. Then the stage of innovation and the search for meaning. And once all that came and would come had come and gone, and all that could happen

had happened, there was a single moment when we decided to be different from all that existed before us. We concluded that we were going to expel all our differences to be ultimately *indifferent*: the defining trait that would sustain us as a race. With the expulsions of our limits came the mass exodus of the qualities of our condition; the characteristics that hindered us from expanding into the unknown, the void that none had surpassed or trespassed. With this power, we gained the ability to have new values beyond the neurons of the minds and bodies of tangible creatures.”

The Oblong Spheroids said that they did not need sleep. Night after night, they gazed at the stars and the blur of their motion, unfailingly awake as they watched the sky spin like a cosmic turntable. They roamed the lands of distant planets, atop molten volcanoes and snowy peaks, under deep tendrils of jungle and past whispers of craterous moons, unconstrained by the condemning world of matter. They did so unembodied, unworrying of a future when their eyesight diminished and their memories faded.

The fleetingness of a lover’s breath. A dying child’s wish to see the future.

A thousand million souls and their hunger for meaning.

“The universe does not care about us. If we do not care about it in return, we are elevated to its same position on the cosmic hierarchy. We become equal to it.”

There was a beauty to what these angels of indifference said, a beauty in the irresistible logic that promised elevation above a universe governed by tangible matter and intangible forces. No longer did generations of children have to suffer nightmares about the thought of death, about the pointlessness of human existence. There was a way out.

Thus, the humans had a graceful sleep.

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First, we place the banana leaves on the ground, one by one, overlapping each other to ensure each crevasse is sealed. After ensuring the surface is flat and clean, we arrange the food: the mounds of steamed rice first, as the base for everything else; the grilled tilapia and bangus second, because they are large; and finally, the various smaller meats around them. We have chicken adobo, lechon kawali, pork barbecue skewers, and grilled shrimp. As a finishing touch, we decorate the edges with fruits and vegetables, any we were able to scavenge.

Tomorrow is All Souls’ Day. Tonight, we feast for the dead.

“It looks delicious,” says Carla when she sees the finished product. Milo is at her side, eager to dig in.

“Remember what I told you,” I tell them. “This is for the dead that deserve veneration. Not for the ones who chose to die.”

They nod.

“Okay,” says Kaori. “*Kain na*.”

Everyone reaches for the food with their hands at the same time.

“A *Kamayan* feast is more than a food ritual that brings people together,” I tell the children as we eat. “It’s our cultural heritage. Our ancestors have done it for generations, even before the Spanish and Americans arrived.”

Kaori and I look at each other, and a shared understanding passes between us. Other than teaching them to refuse the temptations of the Oblong Spheroids, we need to give them a sense of what’s important in life, what we’re fighting for and why.

“It’s a shame much of its history is a mystery,” continues Kaori. “Nowadays most people understand it to have ancient traditional roots, but nothing deeper than that. If we allow a more powerful foreign race to come into our home as they please, even if they are peaceful, we must

show them hospitality, but we must not let them make us forget our way of life.”

I watch Carla help Milo by setting food aside at his corner since his smaller arms can't reach the centre as easily. Then I witness a precious sight: overcome by his adorableness, she leans in and nuzzles her nose against his cheek. He laughs, half-annoyed, half-pleased.

Kaori looks at me and sees me deep in thought. She reaches for my hand.

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After dinner, we tuck the children under their blankets in their spots in the tent. I lead Kaori outside to spend time beside the campfire, under the stars.

I exhale. “I’ve been thinking lately. About what you said back there, about protecting these things about life for our kids. If we truly believe it’s so valuable, I don’t understand why so few of us chose to remain. What do they see that we can’t?”

She pauses to think. She knows me so well, I know she’s devoting the time to formulate words to rekindle my commitment to the cause. This is our routine; we depend on each other to keep us in check.

“Do you remember how my mother was a researcher?”

I nod.

She continues. “She used to tell me lots of things about science and the world. I remember one time, she told me a story about how we’re all stardust. Cosmic grains that originated from the elemental reactions of stars, predating even our solar system. She said the things we believe that make us special above that—above all matter—are our minds and our souls.”

“I know where you’re going with this. Are you saying we’ve always been destined to return to that cosmic ocean?”

She smiles as if she has me right where she wants. “Our minds may think so. As far as we know, they’re just collections of electrical signals firing in the brain. They serve the needs of our cells, and they’re burdened with feeding all those hungry living creatures. But the soul... now that is more interesting, because it doesn’t require the same things the mind or body needs. It doesn’t need food or water. It needs to stay pure, but doing so is easier said than done, and because achieving it is such a mystery, solving it has been the one goal of humanity for as long as we’ve existed. It ties us to immaterial things. It tethers our consciousness to this plane of existence instead of the next, as the Oblong Spheroids try to give us a pathway to. That’s why there are so many old stories about ghosts and spirits wandering the Earth. They are too attached to the world here and are unable to go to Heaven.”

“You said your mother was a scientist?”

“She was religious too. She believed we didn’t make up God for no reason.”

“When you say our souls are tied to the Earth, you mean to say there’s something unaccounted for once we transcend to the oblong state, something we’ll be forced to leave behind.”

“Exactly. There are so many philosophies out there that discuss the same things the Oblong Spheroids show us. *Wu Wei* from Daoism, *Anātman* in Buddhism, Aboriginal *Dreamtime*, Japanese *Mushin*, *Theosis* and being one with God, *Obliteration of the Self*. I’ve thought a lot about it. Perhaps they’re all right, we’ve been on this path of evolution all along and this is the final destination. Finally, the Oblong Spheroids have discovered the winning formula with their *Indifference to the Universe*. It’s all so similar, I think about it a lot.”

“The way they tell their story, it sounds like they transcend time and space,” I say. “Sometimes I think about the implications of that, that some of them could be humans from the past, or humans from the future.”

What am I doing? I can’t entertain these ideas.

I squeeze her hand. “I’m sorry. Don’t think about it, Kaori. Every thought towards the Spheroids’ ideology leads you closer to your death, and closer to their victory.”

We’ve been through many cycles of thinking like this. I expect her to say something reaffirming, something usual, to reattune her allegiance with the way of life we are dedicated to. A reminder of the extra vow we attached during our wedding back in our home village: a promise to preserve our humanity.

But she doesn’t. She’s rescued me from my dissenting thoughts, but now she’s adrift in hers. Her head is tilted to the sky and she’s staring blankly at the stars. The smoke from our campfire drifts into the air, following her gaze. As she contemplates, panic floods my chest, and I ride the storm-born current against my will. I’m terrified she’s accepting indifference, frightened I’m starting to lose her. She needs a drastic reminder.

Gently, I tilt her face to me, kissing her. She welcomes it, pulls me in close, and we begin to make love.

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When the humans woke up and went back to the peak where the Oblong Spheroids had agreed to wait, they asked them to continue their story.

“We once had a precursor with an Idea so powerful, its transmission was above the laws of what you call *physics*.”

A warm sunlit bedroom. A man under the sheets, eyes open to a new day.

“Our precursor woke up one day and did not care about anything. He stayed in his bed and did nothing. When his loved ones tried to get him to move once more, to get on with his normal life, he did not care. They thought him ridiculous, suffering from a mental crisis, or perhaps diseased by paralysis.

“When his wife tried to get him out of bed, he saw her as a collection of trillions of tiny things you call cells, only performing biological tasks to ensure survival, every DNA host’s ultimate goal. If the precursor did not wake up, he would not make money. If he did not make money, they would be doomed to fail in their world. As a result, the wife was desperate to awaken him.

“The precursor saw the light of our sun through his window but *chose* not to see it. It was part of a colour spectrum his human senses were limited to, and he knew there was much more to see than it. The precursor felt the sheets of his bed over his feeble body, his form, but *chose* not to feel it. The feeling only resonated through the nerves of his brain, and he knew there was much more to feel than it. With this process, he gracefully undid emergence, condemning the sum of his parts obsolete. He repeated this until every aspect of his condition was accounted for, until finally, he reached absolute indifference.

“Then came his funeral. The precursor had starved to death, to no surprise. He had sparked an Idea, and though most would think it joined him when he hit the grave, it did not, and it was just the beginning. Soon came multiple reports all around the world of others doing the same as him. The inception of an Idea so complex, they all awoke to the day, yet stayed wrapped in stillness and sheets. A mysterious phenomenon started by this one man. Their loved ones cried and begged them to stop this madness, but they never relented. These precursors eventually all starved to death. And when they did, the world sighed in relief, for they thought it was over. But no, they kept coming. Like a plague washing over our race, more and more of our people practiced this esoteric tradition. In time, most of our kind died by this tedium.

“In your human eyes, this would seem horrific. A nightmare for a species, a species filled with enough ennui to die of starvation on their deathbeds. But they were indifferent to death! They

were indifferent to all, and when you put on the lenses that allow you to see through that indifferent perspective, you will realize that our new planet, one with billions of corpses, was a thriving utopia.

“The act of fulfilling your biological needs is to submit to your condition, to immolate your will in service and obedience to the condition that which governs you. To surrender, to admit defeat, to allow the laws of the cosmos to seize control of your sole self is the one thing that must never happen to achieve the oblong shape.

“That is the end of our story, dear friends. One day, sooner or later, you will learn all this by yourself. One day you will let go of everything, including letting go, and the ideas you think are important now will be insignificant later. One day you will learn that when asking a mate to be yours, the yes or no answer is worthless. One day you will learn that when doing a test that grades your intelligence, the good or bad grade is worthless. One day you will learn that to be successful or poor, to be famous or unknown, to be loved or hated, to be legendary or insignificant, are all worthless. When that time comes, you will be ready to become an Oblong Spheroid.”

The crowd of humans cheered and cried their goodbyes when they began floating into space.

They were like religious celebrities. All over the world, fanatic organizations sprouted, flowering like the timelapse of a blooming garden. Presidents and leaders cited their quotes in campaign speeches all over, unanimous in agreement about the meaning of the words. Kids held their stuffed Oblong Spheroids for comfort against a terrible, palpable world. Crowds formed and chanted, dispersing like waves of the ocean, swallowing everything mankind had ever thought or created.

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I place the flowers on the graves of my grandparents.

A cool breeze wafts through the trees around me, their shadows contrasting the summer's heat. It ruffles the grass and the blades dance like invisible ghosts move through them.

Piety, said my mother, during the day my grandparents died. It's what separates us from them. From those heartless aliens. Piety to family, piety to God. We were made to worship a higher being, not become higher beings ourselves. God put us on this Earth to prove ourselves, to live a good life, to die in a finite number of years. That is unchangeable.

The dead have wielded nihilism as their weapon, but it is ineffective against faith.

Kaori is behind me, respecting my time. When I turn to face her, I sense anxiety in her expression.

I assume it's about the hospital. We searched every corner, but the hospital was empty of medicine. Though I had been rushing through every cabinet and every room, she had been unusually slow during the search, emphasizing the importance of being thorough.

“Let's stay here a little longer,” she mutters. She's doing it again. She looks away, embarrassed.

I shake my head. “It's okay. I know I must hurry. We have to return to Milo.”

“I think he'll be fine. Please, take all the time you need. This is important.”

Her lack of concern scares me. I step closer to her and cradle her protectively. “Are you okay?”

“Nothing's wrong.”

This time, the panic in her voice is unmistakable.

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As originally planned, all four of us were supposed to make the voyage to Baras Town for more medical supplies, doubling as a chance to pay respect to my grandparents where they

originally lived and were buried. Then, if we couldn't find medicine, we would continue northwest to Manila.

Then Milo fell terribly ill. He was in no condition to sail with us, and I was forced to make an impossible decision.

"I can stay behind and look after him," said Carla. "You and Mom go. We need the medicine badly, we can't afford to waste time."

I wasn't comfortable leaving the children behind, but volunteering to sail by myself wasn't an option, either. It violated one of our family rules: never go somewhere alone.

As Kaori and I packed our things for the journey, Carla walked up to me and handed back my grandmother's rosary, the one I gave to Milo.

"He should keep it," I said. "It's his now."

Carla shook her head. It looked like she was holding back tears.

"You'll need it," she said. Then she looked at her mother, and Kaori nodded. Carla nodded back. Seeing as they both agreed, I accepted it, although reluctantly.

Then Carla gave me a desperate hug. "Goodbye, Dad."

I returned it just as strong. "You'll be fine. We'll only be gone for a few hours."

She repeated the same routine with Kaori. "Goodbye, my sweet girl," said Kaori.

As we set sail on our paraw, Kaori was beside me on the ropes, trying to hide her tears.

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I remember last night, the way her eyes seemed devoid of life by the campfire. Then, her detached quickened breaths, her every touch impeccably reserved. The whispers of the dead had planted their roots into her mind that night.

"Kaori," I say, horrified. "What have you done?"

"They're children!" she suddenly cries. "They deserve a chance at a better life! I had to buy us time so they could start the process. We thought about talking to you, but your faith is strong, you would never have listened."

Gently gripping her shoulders, I tell her, "Kaori, what you're giving them isn't life. There is nothing on the other end of the oblong state, no matter what those oblong zealots tell you. You are murdering our children."

She's sobbing, firmly pushing back against my chest. "Just let them go, Miguel."

I don't stop. "Kaori, when we made those wedding vows, we didn't just mean them for the two of us. We meant it for our children too. You promised to help me make new life, to continue our way of living in this world as long as possible. Get out of my way, I have to save them."

Then she explodes. "Save them? You're the one murdering them! The world is in ruin, and other than our village, we don't know if there's anyone else left on the planet. Are you going to condemn them to this terrible life of poor harvests and failed hunts, of radios that will run out of batteries in a few years? Scavenge for scraps from the developed world and relearn how to fish without books or the internet? Make them eat food with their hands on banana leaves, pretend to be part of a culture that has long been dead?"

She looks past me, at my grandparents' graves. "Don't you see? Why do we teach them to remember the dead, when we no longer have to die?"

I look into her eyes, willing her to understand.

"Perhaps we have sinned," I say. "But we were given an impossible choice, and we needed someone to love. Children to love. We're only human, too."

Her silent sobs don't stop, but all the resistance in her body fades. She's given up, finally letting me go.

“Please hurry,” she says quietly. “Save our babies.”

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It’s dark by the time I reach the beach of our encampment. Once I land, I tie the paraw to a wooden post. Though I have no light, I know the path well. I furiously sprint up the path, my heart and mind grotesquely turbulent. For a while, my thoughts spin in vague circles, and worry haunts me like an undead reverie.

I find them in the tent, holding hands and lying face up next to each other on our mattress. Cold horror attacks me as I notice their eyes are wide open, and they stare above lifelessly as if they can see through the top of the tent, past the cover of the overhanging trees, straight at the emerging stars.

I collapse beside them. I check Milo first.

He’s still breathing. “Milo, wake up.”

No response. I check Carla next. She’s still alive as well.

Although I know they can physiologically see me and hear me, they are choosing not to. I realize now the dire circumstances of reaching the oblong state, the alienation it leads us to, and the strangers it conceives out of previous ties.

We are affected by more than the properties that define our existence, constantly oppressed by whispers of cold, hard logic. Although the oblong release from our flesh promised a sublime potential for prosperity, it was also the sum of all of mankind’s worst fears, a dangerous sacrificial demise, an intentional forfeit to science. In the act of seeking foreknowledge, we risk deprivation from the charm of the conscious human experience.

My fingers, shaking terribly, trace the arms of my indifferent children, until they find the intertwined hands of Carla and Milo in the middle. I delicately tangle my hands within them too, combining my presence with theirs, past the physical realm but electrically and lovely as well, until I challenge the Oblong Spheroids and their opposition to the laws of physics. I am an ethereal snake of my own, echoing an inception to their wills to stay my son and daughter in silent, incorporeal breaths that neither hear nor see.

As the evidence compiles that my efforts against the Spheroids’ infinite wisdom are in vain, I recognize a trickling tear from Carla’s eye. My hope is rejuvenated, and I focus on her. I lean close, brushing a thumb on her cheek, squeezing her hand, willing her to come back in hushed tones.

Suddenly, her pupils widen. She coughs, sits straight up, and her eyes register it’s me.

“Dad?”

My response is immediate. “It’s not your fault.”

She wraps her arms around me. Now her tears flow freely. “I’m so sorry. Milo was too sick. Mom and I believed he wouldn’t last much longer, that we were running out of time. And then I thought about how hard our lives are, and I thought about doing it too. I led Milo here to fail everything you taught us, and then I failed too.”

Relief purifies me. I couldn’t save Milo, but I swell with pride for my daughter, who managed to find guilt in mortal liberation, beauty in enduring a perishable existence.

“You’re wrong,” I tell her. “We made a vow to stay behind and remain human. You led Milo here because you wanted to save him, and then you wanted to save yourself too. To me, that is the most human one can be.”

Milo’s body starts to glow.

Carla and I cautiously observe the spectacle. Curious orbs of light begin to spawn from his arms, then his legs, then his face. As they materialize, his entire body starts to fade, as if his essence

is unravelling into fragments, releasing into the air.

“He’s starting to go,” says Carla. “Safe travels, *bunso*.”

I have never seen a person reach the oblong state before. The way the Oblong Spheroids told their story, I imagined they unceremoniously starved to death. For a while, though I renounce all that it stands for, I am awed by the solemn beauty of it. In this moment I forget about the extinction of a species, the ruins of a civilization, the spirits of billions of the dead, and instead focus on the aura of serenity coalesced by the glowing orbs of light around us. They dance, jitter, and float in dazzling patterns, encircling us, their soft glow illuminating our tent.

“It’s beautiful,” Carla breathes.

Regrettably, I agree with her. The view is admirable, and I work hard to memorize the moment, every detail, so that I can replay it later without limit. I clutch onto Carla and she clutches me back, and we press against each other for warmth as we watch Milo dissolve into orbs of light, shining gold like little flying fairies seeping through the tent ceiling, vanishing into the infinite night sky.

#

Kaori steps up to the tombstones of my grandparents and sits down next to me. The shovel I used to dig the third grave for our son is still where I left it, planted upright in the soil in front of me. Though we don’t have his body, the grave is symbolic, an act of defiance. All we hear is the gentle rustling of trees, the chirping of birds, and the trilling of crickets.

God appeared to Moses as an eternal burning bush, and he was awed, Kaori told me last night. *You saw the brilliance of Milo reaching the oblong state, and you were awed as well.*

What is the difference between their faith and ours?

These days, we often get news by radio that another one in our village has chosen to become oblong, perhaps two, or even three. Our numbers dwindle even further.

But we can’t give up now. I don’t think we made the wrong decision, but we can’t let Carla think that we did. The integrity of faith is communal.

Kaori breaks the silence. “She’s too young to recognize it now, but she’s going to hate you when she grows up. She’s going to hate how you made her stay behind while the world is crumbling everywhere, while our family is exploring the cosmos, free from starvation and sleep. She’s going to grow old and die, alone, bitter and frightened. Hating her father. I don’t think I can live with the guilt of sentencing her to such a life, when all she has left to inherit is a land with billions of corpses. Raising her was *our* purpose. We were selfish to use her for that. What will be hers?”

I imagine it. Cold, dark terror. An oblivion of purpose. Then I also imagine how we fail to really die until the memory of us fades, how information is a construct of the mind, how writing and digital bits cannot be interpreted unless a person is educated in the traditions of thousands of years of human progress to decipher them. We will not live forever, but our ideas can. If Carla is the last person in the world to understand our culture, our way of life, our experience, then it will live on. The flame was rekindled with me, only because of the teachings of my mother, only because of the teachings of her mother. There was no logic in this chain, compared to the flawless logic of the Spheroids. But I dared to think we rivalled their infinite indifference in beauty.

I pull out the rosary Carla returned to me.

“Let’s start the *novena* for our son,” I say.

I pull her in close so that our breaths touch each other’s faces, and we start praying.